

INDIAN EXPRESS UPSC IAS EDITION HD 23~06~2026

-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer

writing of other topics in the main exam.

12 Indians killed in Qatar gas plant blast

Divya A
New Delhi, June 22

TWELVE INDIANS were among 13 people killed in an explosion at a gas processing facility in Ras Laffan Industrial City in Qatar on Sunday night.

In a statement, Qatar’s Ministry of Interior said the incident was caused by a “technical malfunction” during operations.

“Qatari authorities have confirmed that 12 Indian nationals have unfortunately passed away in the Ras Laffan incident yesterday night. We extend our »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Goyal-Greer talks start today, trade surplus with US down over 40%

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 22

WHILE COMMERCE Minister Piyush Goyal is scheduled to begin the two-day talks with United States Trade Representative Jamieson Greer on Tuesday to conclude a trade deal by next month, data shows that India’s trade surplus with the US has slipped by over 40% since the negotiations began last year, following Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s meeting with US President Donald Trump on February 13, 2025.

E. EXPLAINED
Across sectors
From petroleum products to electronic components, motor vehicles to fresh fruits, data shows Indian exports are declining while imports from the US are on the rise.

The high-level talks come as the US is set to complete its »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

LEBANON FIGHTING ABATES

Amid peace talks, US waives sanctions on Iran oil for 60 days

Humeyra Pamuk, Dave Graham & Laila Bassam
Buergenstock, Beirut, June 22

THE UNITED States waived sanctions on Iran for 60 days from Monday after the first talks under a nascent peace deal, and officials reported calm in Lebanon after fighting that had prompted Iran to declare the Strait of Hormuz closed.

After a weekend that had seemed to put the week-old peace agreement in jeopardy, including threats from US President Donald Trump to restart the war if Iran closed the strait, tanker traffic started to pick up through the waterway and oil prices resumed their slide. US Vice President J D Vance said his talks with Iranian officials in Switzerland had laid a good foundation for a final peace deal, although Iran denied that



“ There was a little bit of threatening, there was a little bit of whining, but at the end of the day the talks continued and we made great progress.”

J D VANCE, U.S. VICE-PRESIDENT

it had begun discussions of its nuclear programme. »CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Devotees light diyas at the Kheer Bhawani Temple during the annual mela in Ganderbal, J&K, on Monday. SHUAIB MASOODI

Kashmiri Pandits visit Kheer Bhawani temple for mela, welcomed by residents, leaders

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, June 22

THOUSANDS OF people belonging to the Kashmiri Pandit community from different parts of the country assembled at Tulmulla, around 30 km from Srinagar, on Sunday to celebrate Zyeshtha Ashtami and take part in the Kheer Bhawani Mela.

It is one of the most religiously significant days for Kashmiri Pandits and has been a symbol of communal unity in the Kashmir Valley.

On Monday, as Pandits from the Valley and other parts of the country paid obeisance at the Kheer Bhawani temple in Ganderbal district's Tulumulla, they were welcomed by local residents and authorities.

J&K Lt Governor Manoj Sinha and former chief minister Mehbooba Mufti visited the temple, and the Valley's chief cleric Mirwaiz Umar Farooq greeted the Kashmiri Pandits on the occasion of Zyeshtha Ash-tami.

Tight security arrangements were in place as people poured into Tulmulla from early Monday morning and offered milk and kheer (rice pudding) to the goddess. A large number of tourists also arrived at the temple.

The annual festival gives a rare opportunity to Kashmiri Pandits living outside the Valley to return for a few days and to pay obeisance at the sacred temple. The Kheer Bhawani Temple, dedicated to the Goddess Ragnya Devi, is one of the

most sacred Hindu pilgrimage sites in Kashmir.

Lt Governor Sinha offered prayers at the temple also interacted with the Kashmiri Pandit community. "Today, I prayed for the well-being, peace and prosperity of all. May the blessings of Mata Kheer Bhawani be upon everyone. This year, the number of devotees visiting the holy shrine is higher compared to previous years," Sinha told reporters.

Extending greetings on the occasion, J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, who visited the temple a couple of days earlier, expressed hope that the festival would "further strengthen the bonds of harmony, brotherhood and rich composite cultural heritage of Jammu and Kashmir".

Former chief minister and People's Democratic Party (PDP) president Mehbooba Mufti visited the temple on Monday and said, "I am happy that they (Kashmiri Pandits) are coming and that the people here are giving them a warm welcome."

"I would appeal to them that whatever happened in the past, they should forget that and focus on the future," she added. She asked the Pandits to sideline people "who weaponise their sufferings".

The Valley's chief cleric, Mirwaiz Umar Farooq, extended his greeting to Kashmiri Pandits on the occasion. "May this day renew the spirit of mutual respect, brotherhood and the shared heritage of Kashmir that we inherited," he said.

Trade surplus with US down

• Imports from US rising, exports falling

	U.S. IMPORTS TO INDIA (in \$ million)			INDIA'S EXPORTS TO U.S. (in \$ million)		
	March 2025	March 2026	Growth %	March 2025	March 2026	Growth %
Petroleum products	139	321	130	309	235	-24
Electronic component	182	431	136	203	135	-33
Organic chemicals	86	172	98	115	101	-12
Copper products	29	75	159	38	31	-18
Motor vehicles/Cars	1	14	1,284	2	1	-37
Fresh fruits	113	131	15	2	1	-10

SOURCE: COMMERCE AND INDUSTRY MINISTRY

Section 301 investigation by next month and come out with a new tariff architecture, which could act as an alternative to reciprocal tariffs. After over a year of trade tension between India and the US, government officials said Goyal and Greer are expected to give "the final touch" to the first tranche of the trade agreement.

Meanwhile, data released by the Commerce and Industry Ministry showed that India's export surplus slipped over 40% to \$2.94 billion in May this year, from \$5.02 billion in May 2025. Data suggests that India's surplus has been declining in multiple categories beyond energy.

Ahead of Greer's visit, several farm groups have reiterated that the US has one of the largest farm subsidy programmes, and the government should stick to its stance in the World Trade Organisation (WTO) and refrain from commitment on farm imports, which could hurt the interests of apple, almond, walnut, soybean, cotton and rubber growers.

Declining export surplus

The fears of higher imports from the US come as India's export surplus is already declin-

ing due to various concessions that India agreed to during the negotiations. Right before Modi's visit to the US last year, India reduced duty on American bourbon whiskey and slashed tariff on Harley-Davidson motorcycles.

Last November, Indian public sector refiners also signed a one-year deal for American liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) imports, marking the first structured contract of US LPG for the domestic market. The deal stated that India would import around 2.2 million tonnes per annum (MTPA) of LPG from the US, which is close to 10% of India's annual imports. Amid disruption in LNG imports from West Asia, US turned into India's top source for LNG in May, as per data shared by commodity market analytics firm Kpler.

A push for higher imports from the US came as India, for the better part of 2025, was bargaining to get lower tariff rates. However, the US imposed 50% duty for months until the US Supreme Court declared it illegal in February this year.

Competition from US

Data showed that several Indian exports have been declining in the same categories where US imports are on the

rise, signalling potential competition. Government officials have claimed that US goods are not price-competitive as compared to Indian manufacturers.

In March this year, India's petroleum product exports to the US slipped by 24.02% to \$235.47 million, as compared to \$309.91 million in March 2025. India's imports in March under the same category increased by 130.95% to \$321.73 million, as compared to \$139.31 million in March 2025.

Another high-volume product category where US imports have been gaining ground is electronic components. While India's exports of electronic components in March this year slipped by 33.41% to \$135.54 million, from \$203.54 million in March 2025, India's imports under this category jumped by 136.30% to \$431.89 million in March 2026 as compared to \$182.77 million in March 2025.

A similar trend was visible in organic chemicals, copper products, motor vehicles and fresh fruits, where exports slipped between 10 to 40% and imports jumped between 15 to 1285%. India's imports of scientific instruments have also been increasing.

Farmers' appeal

The most sensitive element

in the US-India trade dynamics continues to be agriculture trade. Modi, during his Independence Day speech last year, had said that India would not compromise on the well-being of its farmers, fisherfolk, and cattle-keepers.

Harish Chauhan, Convenor, Hill States Horticulture Forum, said on Monday that the proposal for permitting apple imports from the US above a Minimum Import Price (MIP) does not appear to provide adequate protection to Indian apple growers, as imports from the US are already taking place at prices above the proposed threshold.

"Given the unique agro-climatic conditions of Himachal Pradesh, Jammu & Kashmir and Uttarakhand, growers of apples, almonds and walnuts have limited opportunities to shift to alternative crops. Any significant increase in imports resulting from tariff reductions would therefore have severe consequences for their livelihoods and the rural economy of these hill states," Chauhan said.

KV Biju, National Coordinator, Rashtriya Kisan Mahasangh, in a letter to Modi on Monday, said the biggest concern was US agricultural subsidies as the US Farm Bill allocated \$956 billion in 2014 and \$1.5 trillion in 2024. According to the OECD (2024), the Producer Support Estimate (PSE) is +7.1% in the US, while Indian farmers face a negative PSE of -14.5%, effectively amounting to implicit taxation.

"Allowing imports of heavily subsidised US agricultural products will destroy domestic production in affected sectors. India has historically opposed US farm subsidies at the WTO. Permitting subsidised imports now would undermine that long-standing position and the solidarity of countries that supported India in challenging such subsidies," Biju said.

Iran oil sanctions

The two sides, trying to build on the interim deal they signed last week, agreed to a roadmap towards a permanent agreement within 60 days at the talks in the Qatari-owned Swiss mountain resort of Buergenstock, mediators Pakistan and Qatar said.

They also agreed on a mechanism to end fighting in Lebanon between US ally Israel and Iran-aligned Hezbollah, and opened a communications line to help ensure safe passage for commercial ships through the strait. In the first major step of several foreseen under the agreement to provide Iran with economic benefits, the US Treasury announced a waiver until August 21 on sanctions, allowing Iran to sell oil and related products and receive payment for them.

Vance, who has maintained a largely upbeat tone since the memorandum of understanding was signed, said Tehran had agreed to allow in nuclear inspectors, and to establish mechanisms to handle its assets frozen abroad and manage ceasefires. "We laid a very good foundation for a successful final deal," he told reporters after taking part in the talks.

However, Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmaeil Baghaei told the official IRNA news agency that Iran had not yet discussed nuclear issues or made new commitments.

Iran has limited inspections by the International Atomic Energy Agency since the US and Israel launched a first round of air strikes last year, and suspended them entirely when war broke out in February. It says its nuclear programme is peaceful.

Vance played down the tensions that had emerged over the weekend, which were driven by escalating fighting in Lebanon, Iran's new declaration that it had again closed the strait, and an angry response from Trump. "There was a little bit of threatening, there was a little bit of whining, but at the end of the day the talks continued and we made great progress," Vance said.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araqchi said on social media that Tehran had secured waivers for oil and petrochemical exports, the release of some of its frozen assets abroad and the launch of a reconstruction and development plan for Iran.

Vance said White House envoy Jared Kushner, Trump's son-in-law, had come up with a process whereby the US and Qatar would have control over Iranian funds when they are unfrozen, and the money could be spent on US corn, soy and wheat.

Oil prices drop

Technical talks were due to continue for the rest of this week.

The interim peace agreement calls for ending all hostilities, including in Lebanon, which Israel invaded in March after Hezbollah fired across the border. Israel was not party to the peace agreement and says it will not withdraw its troops from Lebanon, but on Friday it agreed to a new ceasefire.

Though intense fighting continued for another day, Lebanese officials said it had abated since Saturday night. Hassan Wazni, director of a hospital in Nabatieh, a city in the south that has been heavily bombarded during the conflict, said it was the first two full days of calm since the war began. "I'm monitoring the situation day by day, and most of the time I'm sleeping in the hospital. This is the longest a ceasefire has held," he told Reuters by phone.

More than a million Lebanese have been displaced by the war, and though some have begun returning to their homes, many are still too wary.

In Qennarit, a southern town, mourners carried the bodies of four women killed in Saturday's wave of Israeli strikes. The coffins were draped in yellow Hezbollah flags with the group's green logo of an arm holding an assault rifle.

Meanwhile, reflecting the reduced tensions, the Israeli military lifted safety restrictions in eight communities in northern Israel near the Lebanese border.

Lebanese President Joseph Aoun discussed efforts to maintain the ceasefire and halt Israeli military escalation during a phone call with Vance, Qatar's Prime Minister, and Kushner, the Lebanese presidency said.

Israeli President Isaac Herzog said Israel was not opposed to a diplomatic end to the Iran war, but any agreement must ensure Tehran cannot use funds it receives as part of the deal for military purposes or to support regional proxies. REUTERS

Qatar gas plant blast

deepest condolences to the bereaved families and prayers for the departed souls," the Indian Embassy in Doha said in a post on X on Monday.

The identities of the deceased are not known yet. While many of the injured are also Indians, the Embassy said they were "stable".

"Qatari authorities have also confirmed that all those who got injured in the incident are in stable condition and are receiving appropriate medical treatment. Our Embassy is working in close contact with the Qatari authorities to extend all possible help to the Indian nationals and their families affected by this incident, including ensuring that mortal remains of the deceased are sent to India at the earliest," it said.

Confirming the deaths at a press conference in Doha,

Qatar's Energy Minister Saad bin Sherida Al Kaabi said: "I find myself today having to do something I have always hoped will never happen, and that is to announce the tragic loss of 13 lives of our people who hold Indian and Pakistani nationalities. Sixty-six people have been reported injured and are receiving medical treatment, none of whom are in life-threatening condition".

"I would like to emphasise that this was an accident and not sabotage or hostile in nature," he said, according to AP.

The Indian community is the largest expatriate group in Qatar, with over 830,000 Indians residing and working across various industries. Ras Laffan is Qatar's central natural gas hub, employing thousands of engineers, technicians and labourers, many of whom are Indians.



TOP INSTITUTES HAVE BACKED GOVT PLAN TO INCENTIVISE HYBRIDS

Should strong hybrids be cheaper?

Key question as EV policy call nears

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, June 22

PROVISIONS RELATING to strong hybrid vehicles in Delhi's new Electric Vehicle (EV) Policy continue to be debated as the existing policy, which has already been extended multiple times, nears expiry. The new EV Policy 2026-30 is expected to be placed before the Cabinet at its next meeting.

Over the past couple of months since the draft policy was put in the public domain, the Delhi Transport Department has received more than 700 responses, and the suggestions are under review, officials said.

There is a clear divergence of opinion over exempting strong hybrids from road tax. A strong (or 'full') hybrid vehicle combines a traditional internal combustion engine with a powerful electric motor and a larger battery, which enables it to run entirely on electric power at low speeds, and to switch automatically to the engine for higher speeds. A mild hybrid, by contrast, has a smaller electric motor and battery, and cannot run on electricity alone. The electric motor in mild hybrids acts only to boost acceleration and smoothen stop-start systems.

"The government wants to provide road tax exemptions on buying strong hybrid vehicles at least for the first couple of years so that the public can gradually switch to electric vehicles... Several stakeholders have also backed the policy and the proposed incentives on strong hybrid vehicles. However, there is resistance from some quarters," a senior Transport officer told *The Indian Express*.

Critics have argued that in-

E. EXPLAINED

What is strong hybrid?

Strong Hybrid Vehicle uses a combination of an electric motor and an internal combustion engine. This helps optimise fuel efficiency as well as performance.

stead of providing incentives to strong hybrids, the government should invest in charging infrastructure and push the adoption of pure EVs.

The draft EV Policy has proposed a 50 per cent exemption on road tax and registration charges for strong hybrids with an ex showroom price up to Rs 30 lakh.

Several top institutes and consultants working to promote electric mobility, such as the IITs and the International Road Federation (IRF), have backed the government's plan to incentivise strong hybrids, the officer said.

"The incentives on strong hybrids have been proposed after proper research and studying similar policies implemented in other states. For instance, Uttar Pradesh allowed 100 per cent exemption on strong hybrid vehicles for almost a year and a half, and both the government's revenues and vehicle registrations increased during this period, even as Delhi lost out to UP in revenues," the official said.

Auto industry data show that before strong hybrids were exempt from road tax in UP in July 2024, an average of 538 such vehicles were registered in the state every month; this

Haryana nod to tax concessions to replace old trucks, buses in NCR

Gurgaon: In a major push towards reducing vehicular emissions and improving air quality in the National Capital Region (NCR), the Haryana Cabinet on Monday approved a scheme providing substantial motor vehicle tax concessions for the replacement of old trucks and buses complying with BS-IV or earlier emission norms. The Cabinet, which met under the chairmanship of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, approved the grant of exemption in motor vehicle tax for replacement of old trucks and buses registered in Gurgaon, Faridaabad and other NCR districts of Haryana. The decision has been taken in accordance with the scheme for support to the National Capital Region Planning Board.

According to official estimates, the scheme has the potential to benefit approxi-



mately 93,458 trucks and 16,329 buses operating in the NCR districts of Haryana. The government expects the initiative to play an important role in fleet modernisation. Under the scheme, eligible beneficiaries replacing their old vehicles will be entitled to a 100% concession in motor vehicle tax on the purchase of new trucks and buses complying with BS-VI or stricter emission norms.

The concession will also be available for EV and CNG trucks and buses purchased under the scheme. **ENS**

number increased by 175 per cent on average after the incentives were introduced. Also, the state's monthly revenues under this head increased by 60 per cent from an average Rs 29 crore per month to Rs 47 crore per month. "In just one year, UP collected revenue of Rs 500 crore by incentivising strong hybrid vehicles," the official said.

According to officials, incentivising strong hybrids will also help bridge the adoption gap as the EV charging infrastructure is gradually strengthened in the capital.

"Giving incentives will gradually nudge the public towards switching to electric mobility," the official said.

In its submission to the government, CUTS International, a public policy research and advocacy organisation, has said: "...The [proposed] 50% road tax waiver recognizes the role of strong hybrids as an effective transition technology. Self-charging hybrids operate in electric mode for around 60% of urban driving and deliver about 25-35% reduction in CO2 emissions compared to conven-

tional vehicles, offering immediate benefits without dependence on charging infrastructure."

It has also pointed out that "in the absence of such incentives earlier, consumers were registering hybrid cars in neighbouring states such as Uttar Pradesh and Haryana, leading to an estimated annual revenue loss of Rs 400-500 crore for Delhi. By rationalizing the tax structure, the policy effectively reverses this trend, turning a revenue leakage into a revenue-positive outcome while simultaneously supporting cleaner technologies..."

IRF, a global nonprofit based in Washington DC, has commended the Delhi government for proposing the incentive. "...The decision to extend a 50% road tax waiver for strong hybrid cars is a timely and progressive step... They offer an immediate and practical pathway for reducing emissions without dependence on external charging infrastructure," the IRF has said.

Nat Zero Energy Transition Association (NETRA), a global nonprofit that works on promoting cleaner energy, has argued that "a 50% waiver of road tax on SHEVs (strong hybrid electric vehicles) is not likely to result in revenue loss to the exchequer vis-à-vis a petrol equivalent vehicle but will resolve the anomaly of higher tax being paid by consumers on a cleaner technology (SHEV) as compared to a petrol car."

According to Nomura Research Institute (NRI), "inclusion of hybrids in the road tax exemption policy signals a phased approach by the government, with hybrids acting as a bridge to curb vehicular pollution till the full EV transition goal can be realized."

• **BRIEFLY**

Meanwhile, monsoon floods have begun to set in parts of north and upper Assam, particularly in Dhemaji district, where a total of 14,562 people were affected by flooding till Monday evening, according to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority. Relief centres have also been set up in Dhemaji and Lakhimpur districts.



• ENVIRONMENT

ESA for Western Ghats: Why conservation is key

The proposal aims to protect one of India's richest biodiversity hotspots, but consensus on defining ecologically sensitive areas remains elusive so far



NIKHIL GHANEKAR

THE WESTERN Ghats, a 1,500-km long chain of largely unbroken mountains which fringes off the western coast of India, is one of the country's most famous natural ecosystems, next only to the Himalayas. Unlike the Himalayas, the Western Ghats are densely populated and have been an economic hub for states abutting India's west coast, and is home to famous cash crops.

A special regime of legal protection, conservation, and sustainable development prescribed for this fragile ecosystem has been hanging fire due to objections and concerns of the six state governments — Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu — where the Ghats extend.

Separate protections for the Ghats region were initially prescribed by the famous Madhav Gadgil-led expert panel, and later by a high-level working group, chaired by former Indian Space Research Organisation chief K Kasturirangan.

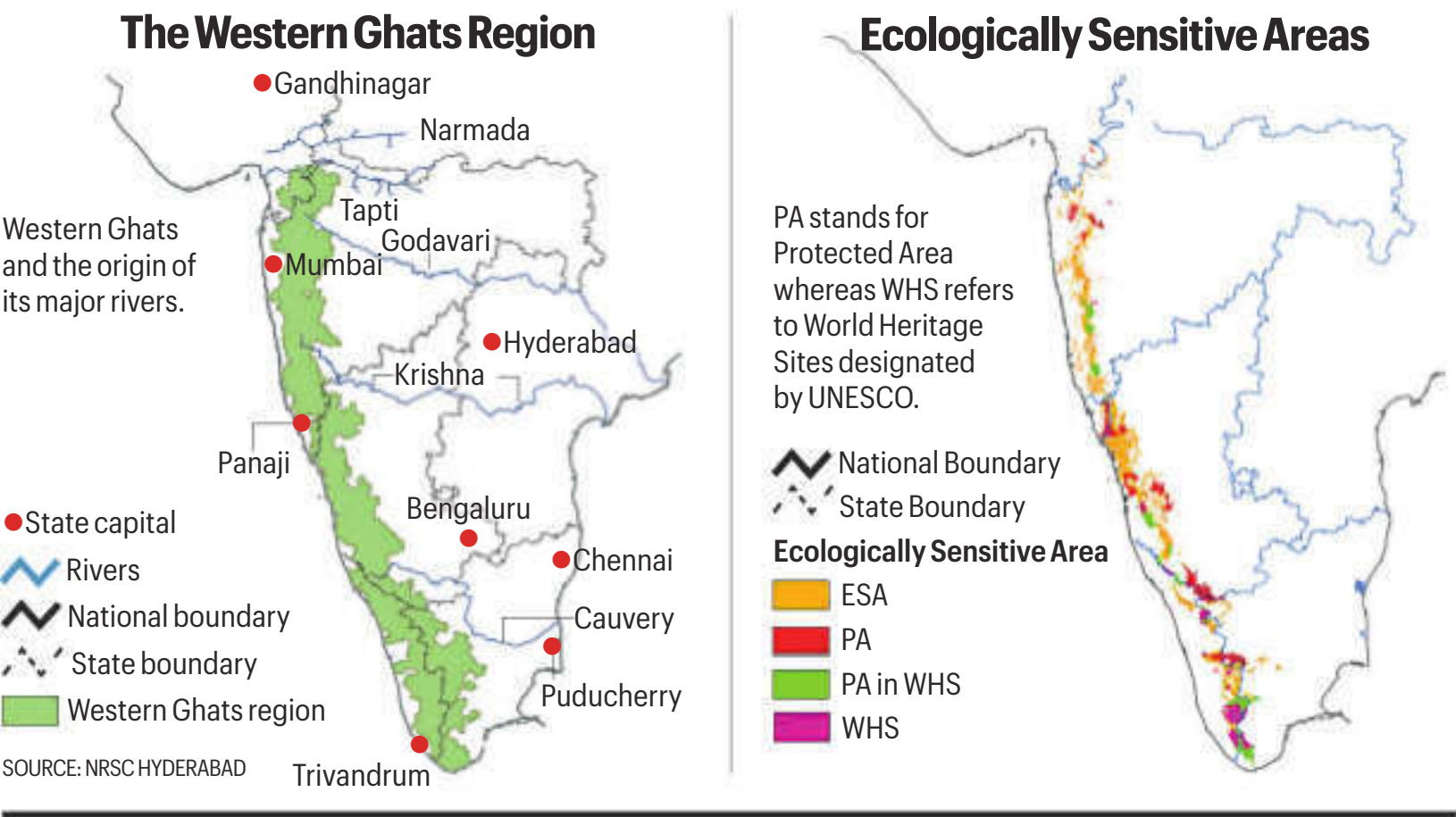
It is in this backdrop of the Kasturirangan panel's 2013 report that the Centre demarcated 56,825 sq km as ecologically sensitive area (ESA) in a draft notification. With a lack of consensus that continued till 2022, the Centre constituted a fresh expert committee with the task of re-examining the objections by the six states, keeping the Ghats' conservation and needs of the region in mind.

The story so far

The Kasturirangan panel's report identified an area of 1,64,280 sq km, whereas the Gadgil panel identified 1,29,037 sq km as the Ghats's extent. Compared with the Gadgil panel — which recommended that the entire area be designated as ESA with heavy cross-sectoral restrictions — the Kasturirangan panel adopted a different approach.

Its analysis found that 60% of the Ghats region was already under "cultural landscape", which was human dominated and where land was under settlements, plantations, or agriculture. The remaining 40% — 60,000 sq km — was classified as "natural landscape", a high biological richness,

• THE EXTENT OF DEMARCATION



low fragmentation, low population density, and inclusive of national parks, and tiger and elephant habitats.

The panel proposed that this 60,000 sq km be notified as ESA along with a ban on mining, quarrying, red category polluting industries, thermal power plants, and large constructions and townships. In the past, ESAs have been notified in Dahanu, Mahabaleshwar-Panchgani, and Doon valley taking into account the area's biological diversity and need to regulate activities.

The then United Progressive Alliance government accepted these recommendations in-principle. But on the back of concerns raised by state governments on wide restrictions on industries, it asked the six states time to submit their views before finalising the ESA boundaries in December 2013.

Later, in March 2014, the Centre also issued a draft notification, demarcating 56,825.7 sq km as ESA. The area was reduced by over 3,000 sq km on account of Kerala's submission, based on their own ground truthing exercise, that sought omission of several agricultural areas, orchards, horticultural plots, plantation and residential areas outside the remit of ESA.

Six iterations of the draft notification have been issued since 2014, with the latest one issued on July 31, 2024, and valid until the end of July 2026. The latest notification

Biodiversity hotspot

The Ghats are home to nearly 2,000 species of plants, 84 species of fish, 87 species of amphibians, 89 species of reptiles, 15 bird species, and 12 mammals, which are endemic or only found there.

There are 61 protected areas — national parks or sanctuaries — notified in the region.

made a subtle but crucial deviation from the past ones, and inserted a provision proposing to finalise or publish ESA demarcation in either a phased, state-wise manner, or through a combined notification. This was done ostensibly to not hold back ESA declaration in states where a consensus with states is around the corner.

After each round of re-notification, the Environment Ministry has attempted to get state governments to sign-off on the final ESA extent, only to be pegged back by either fresh demands, or deadlock over unresolved disputes.

Inching towards partial resolution

The expert committee appointed in 2022, under Sanjay Kumar, former Director General of Forests, Environment Ministry, has held several meetings with state governments, and has undertaken field visits in all states except Kerala. Sources aware of developments said that some of the fundamental issues the committee has sought to resolve are reconciliation of village-level data, names, revenue details, based on satellite imagery, and information provided by state governments.

It has also considered formulations on providing some sort of financial incentives to the six states for protecting the Ghats, which could eventually be recommended in its final report to the Centre. The Kastu-

rirangan panel had recommended that the six states "should come together to negotiate for a grant-in aid" from the Centre in return for protecting natural resources. It also recommended some financial arrangement for payments for ecosystem services accruing from ESA and non-ESA regions with the Ghats.

Even as there has been progress on resolution, states have proposed further reduction in the ESA. It remains to be seen whether the expert committee will agree to the reductions in its final report.

Kerala and Karnataka remain the two states where consensus is not any closer. Karnataka has been steadfast in its total rejection of the Kasturirangan panel recommendations. Kerala, meanwhile, has sought to reduce the earlier 9,993.7 sq km area by another 1,000 sq km or so, arguing to omit villages from Idukki due to plantation, agriculture activities, especially in Cardamom Hills.

In Maharashtra, the state government has sought exclusion of 378 villages from the 2,133 notified in the draft notification, according to reliable sources. Sources said that the state has argued to omit villages for industries, mining, and because some villages are distant from ESAs.

Why the Ghats need protection

The Ghats find their formation in a combination of factors such as tectonic movements, volcanic eruptions, and years of erosion. The continuous mountain chain, with a break at Palakkad Gap, is a treasure trove of biodiversity, harbouring hundreds of plants and animals only found in this region, and is one of the eight "hot-test hotspots" of biological diversity.

Its landform influences the monsoon by acting as a physical barrier against moisture-carrying winds, giving bountiful rain on the coastal side of the Ghats. The abundant rain and dense forests also nurture springs, and give life to Godavari, Krishna, Cauvery, Periyar, and numerous other rivers, which drive economic growth and sustain livelihood.

Moreover, this region is not sparsely populated and has historically seen plantations and cultivation of pepper, cardamom, cinnamon, mango, and jackfruit. This necessitates conservation of the region from polluting industries.

Kerala has seen civil society protests arguing for more protection and omission of villages from ESAs. Similar protests have also been seen in Goa, Karnataka, and Maharashtra.

• LAW

Right to walk on footpaths: Behind SC order, surge in pedestrian deaths

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, June 22

THE SUPREME Court Friday recognised walking on demarcated footpaths as a fundamental right that shall override the privilege of a motor vehicle. The court also urged the government to introduce a law to bring this right into effect, which would be crucial to holding officials and departments accountable for addressing violations of pedestrian rights.

The genesis of the case lies in the death of a five-year-old boy, who was struck by a tanker while walking to school with his father.

Pedestrians are among the most vulnerable road users in India. The little space available to them is frequently encroached upon by two-wheelers or shops. Pedestrian deaths have more than doubled in 10 years and now account for the second highest road death share after two-wheeler fatalities.

An analysis by *The Indian Express* shows that while total road fatalities increased by 21.24% between 2015 and 2024, pedestrian deaths surged by nearly 163%, or 2.63 times. The number of pedestrians killed in road accidents rose from 13,894 in 2015 to 36,526 in 2024. Their share in total road fatalities also more than doubled, from 9.5% to 20.61% during the period. Pedestrian fatalities continued to rise even during the Covid-19 pandemic years (*see table*).

• INDIA'S DEADLY ROADS

	Year	Total road deaths	Pedestrian deaths	Share (%)
	2015	1,46,133	13,894	9.5
	2016	15,0,785	15,746	10.5
	2017	1,47,913	20,457	13.8
	2018	1,51,417	22,656	15
	2019	1,51,113	25,858	17.1
	2020	1,31,714	23,483	17.8
	2021	1,53,972	29,124	18.9
	2022	1,68,491	32,825	19.48
	2023	1,72,890	35,221	20.37
	2024	1,77,175	36,526	20.61

SOURCE: ROAD ACCIDENT IN INDIA, MORTH NOTE: 2020 AND 2021 ARE COVID-19 YEARS

Right to walk

In its judgment, the SC traced the issue back to the most basic human activity — walking. The court highlighted the irony that while walking predates wheeled transport by millennia, road infrastructure today is overwhelmingly designed for vehicles.

It observed that the Motor Vehicles Act has, in many ways, undermined the rights of pedestrians.

The court went on to say that the absence of safe and comfortable footpaths, and their subjugation to motor transport, has been a "civilisational problem".

Piyush Tiwari, founder and CEO, SaveLIFE Foundation, said that the court has reversed the hierarchy over motorised vehicles, since pedestrians account for one in five road deaths in India. "For municipal bodies and road-owning agencies, a safe, unobstructed footpath is no longer discretionary; it is a constitutional duty wherever a road exists," he said.

Motor Vehicles Act

The court came down heavily on the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, an exhaustive legislation governing the vehicles and rules of the road. The court said that the law is not for protecting the right to walk on footpaths and only lays down infrastructure for vehicles, which is its mainstay.

"The Motor Vehicles Act is built upon 'vehicle' as the subject of the legislation, while 'human' interests are incidental, which a motor vehicle must avoid violating — that's all, and no further," said the court.

In 2017, the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways notified the Motor Vehicles (Driving) Regulations, which says that drivers should take special precautions to ensure safety of vulnerable road users such as pedestrians, cyclists, children, etc.

The court, however, said that these regulations are just guiding principles and they neither recognise the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths nor prioritise the right to footpath over a motorised road.

New Delhi

The Ideas Page

TUESDAY, JUNE 23, 2026



PALLAV SHISHODIA

THE SUPPORT of a majority of legislators in the Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha is needed to form a stable government. This stability has often been missing due to the defections by “*aaya* Rams, *gaya* Rams” toppling elected governments. To address this, in 1985, the Tenth Schedule was added by way of the 52nd Amendment to the Constitution “for outlawing defection” by disqualifying any elected members who defect from or defy the whip of the political party to which they belong, except in the case of a split or merger. The underlying premise of this Schedule is that the elected representatives cannot be trusted with political morality, loyalty to their own party, and independent judgment beyond party lines.

The Tenth Schedule’s validity was challenged in the *Kihoto Hollohan* case as violative of the fundamental rights to freedom of speech and conscience, and to dissent and to dissociate from the party line. And that it suppressed democratic debate, dialogue, and disagreements. The challenge was negated by a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in favour of party discipline to check the unprincipled and unethical flight of members of the House. Then followed several judicial decisions with nuanced interpretations of defection, the role of the Speaker, and the relationship between a political party and its

The ruling parties, at whatever level, rule with the iron fist of a whip on their members and the parties in opposition remain vulnerable to poaching, despite the seemingly high threshold for split and merger

legislative wing. By the 91st Amendment in 2003, the exemption from disqualification in the case of a split was removed, leaving only the possibility of a merger requiring the agreement of two-thirds of the members of the legislative party.

The shifting loyalties and fluidity of our politics make our elected representatives cross over to political opponents time and again, despite the Tenth Schedule. The force of the original electoral verdict has often been dismantled by split-and-merger. Rarely is the elected representative who defects disqualified, particularly when the defection is with the blessing of the ruling party. In very few cases, the resignation of elected representatives is followed by their re-election under the banner of a new party.

In the ongoing crisis of the TMC, the defection, described as a split, is followed by a merger with a nondescript NCPI to save the remaining tenure of the rebel MPs. A major faction of Shiv Sena (UBT) is on the same path. In all probability, the original TMC/Shiv Sena (UBT) leadership will challenge this as defection to seek the disqualification of rebel MPs. The status quo pending the challenge will suit everyone.

Elected representatives in mature democracies, like the UK, often take a political position different from their political party. In

the US, Republicans vote openly, and at times with prior announcement, with Democrats, or vice versa. We fear this as a charter for indiscipline and horse-trading to defeat or topple the original mandate in a given election.

Some fundamental questions arise about the very desirability of the Tenth Schedule. Isn’t there a stifling of intra-party democracy in all the political parties because of the structure it created? Why can’t an elected representative be trusted even for five years and, if she commits defection, be answerable only to her own constituency?

It would be facile to say that the Tenth Schedule has made defections, toppling of elected governments and horse-trading much more difficult, expensive or infrequent. The ruling parties, at whatever level, rule with the iron fist of a whip on their members and the opposition parties remain vulnerable to poaching, despite the seemingly high threshold for split and merger. The high-command culture with the virtual disappearance of inner-party democracy is among the worst, if unintended, consequences of the Tenth Schedule. A re-appraisal is needed after four decades of this messy anti-defection law. It is time to think of its complete abolition and re-imagine our party politics on a more mature platform of political accountability.

The writer is a senior advocate

Supreme Court has put pedestrians first. Cities must, too



KAUSHIK DAS GUPTA

IMAGINE A city where streets are not merely conduits for vehicles but public spaces where people can walk safely — through neighbourhoods, and to schools, markets, workplaces and recreation centres. In the Indian context, such a vision remains fraught. An analysis in this newspaper shows that while overall road fatalities rose by 21.24 per cent between 2015 and 2024, deaths among those travelling on foot surged by nearly 163 per cent. The number of people killed while walking increased from 13,894 in 2015 to 36,526 in 2024. That’s why the Supreme Court’s judgment — it held that the right to walk safely on demarcated footpaths is a fundamental right flowing from Article 21 of the Constitution and must take precedence over the movement of motor vehicles — is significant.

All too often, the pedestrian is marginal to urban planning. That is despite data from the last Census showing that more than 4 crore Indians engaged in non-agricultural pursuits walk to work every day. For another large section, the journey involves walking to bus stops and Metro or train stations. Yet, urban development is routinely equated with wider roads, flyovers and faster traffic flows. Footpaths, where they exist, are often narrow, broken, encroached upon, or abruptly disappear. There is very little regard for safe crossings for the elderly, children or persons with disabilities.

Policymakers should pay particular heed to the Court’s criticism of the inequality that lies at the core of this automobile-centred urban imagination. “It could also be elitism to start with, for machines with wheels were only for the rich, but as economies progressed and cheaper motor vehicles were introduced, the entire spectrum of motorised transportation dominated the roads, pushed aside the walkers to the extent that they are treated as a nuisance for the drivers who routinely run over the walkers and their footpaths,” it said while delivering its verdict in a road-accident case that resulted in the death of a five-year-old walking to his school.

Despite several amendments, mechanised transport continues to hold centre stage in the Motor Vehicles Act. As the Court pointed out, even the latest regulations, incorporated in the Act nine years ago, “neither recognise the fundamental right to walk on demarcated footpaths nor prioritise the right to footpath over a motorised road”. Urban planning around the world is increasingly recognising that walkable cities are also more liveable cities. Studies and real-world examples show that pedestrian-friendly urban centres lower pollution and congestion, strengthen social interaction, and even stimulate economic activity. Copenhagen has made walking and cycling integral to everyday life, while Bogotá and Kigali’s transport models recognise that every public commute begins and ends on foot. The lesson is equally evident in India. A 2019 ITDP study found that the construction of new footpaths in Chennai reduced dependence on motorised transport by 9 to 27 per cent, cut greenhouse-gas emissions and expanded economic opportunities for women and persons with disabilities. The message — that a city that enables its residents to walk safely is likely to be a healthier and cleaner one — is salient given the country’s struggle with pollution and lifestyle diseases.

Of course, there can be no template to democratise mobility. Several of the interventions adopted elsewhere may not be completely transplantable to Indian cities that have high population densities, large informal settlements, mixed land use and severe constraints on urban land. Even then, the SC verdict invites planners to engage with a more fundamental question: Can cities be designed to enable people to go about their daily commitments regardless of whether they own a vehicle? Retrofitting older cities, with their narrow roads and entrenched patterns of development, could prove difficult and expensive. But as the SC has underlined, unobstructed footpaths are not extravagant interventions but minimum conditions for the exercise of the fundamental right to movement. In that sense, its verdict should be seen as an invitation to organise cities around accessibility.

The judgment is also consequential because India’s urban story is still being written. Dozens of new urban centres and peri-urban settlements are expected to emerge in the coming decades as the country’s population becomes increasingly urban. The choices will determine whether these cities replicate the mistakes of automobile-centric planning or embrace a more equitable model.

*The writer is senior associate editor, The Indian Express
kaushik.dasgupta@gmail.com*



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

INDIAN REFINERS STUDYING TECHNO-COMMERCIAL FEASIBILITY

US sanctions waiver in; Tehran dials refiners, traders for oil sales

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 22

THE NATIONAL Iranian Oil Company (NIOC) has started reaching out to international oil companies, including Indian refiners, and trading houses to resume commercial ties in a bid to restart its global oil exports, according to trade sources.

This comes against the backdrop of the US-Iran memorandum of understanding (MoU) being in place, with the first round of talks under the terms of the initial pact indicating progress between Washington and Tehran.

The MoU, which was inked last week, mentioned that the US will initially issue sanctions waivers for Iranian crude and petroleum products, until it terminates its sanctions on Iranian oil and its trade. On Monday evening (India time) the US Department of the Treasury issued a temporary 60-day waiver, allowing production, delivery, and sale of Iranian oil, petroleum products, and petrochemicals through August 21.

The US has also committed to removing its naval blockade of Iranian ports. Both measures

are being counted upon by the NIOC to move its oil — which has for years been predominantly exported to China — to the wider international market, trade sources said.

Indian refiners have also recently received communication from the NIOC, it is learnt.

A senior refinery executive said that refiners' trading teams are in touch with the Iranian side and deliberations are on regarding the techno-commercial feasibility of lifting Iranian oil under the arrangement listed in the US-Iran MoU.

Iran used to be a major source of crude oil for the country, but New Delhi stopped buying its oil in 2019 after the first Donald Trump administration walked away from the Iran nuclear deal and reimposed sanctions on Tehran.

After a gap of nearly seven years, Indian refiners bought Iranian crude again in April after the US issued a month-long sanctions waiver in a bid to bring more oil to the global market amid the West Asia war and the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz. But once that waiver lapsed, imports from Tehran stopped again.

INDIAN REFINERS AVOID SANCTIONED OIL

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INDIAN REFINERS steer clear of oil and gas under US sanctions to avoid the risk of attracting



secondary sanctions from Washington

India imported about 530,000 tonnes of Iranian oil in April, as per data from the Directorate General of Commercial Intelligence and Statistics (DGCIS). Indian refiners steer clear of oil and gas under US sanctions to avoid the risk of attracting secondary sanctions from Washington.

"We have been holding regular discussions on the techno-commercial feasibility of buying Iranian oil. Our teams are working to ensure that they are pre-

pared to buy Iran's crude when it is available, as per our requirement and its viability in terms of payment mechanisms and other logistical considerations," said a senior refinery executive, who didn't wish to be identified. The executive said NIOC recently reached out to his firm regarding resumption of oil trade.

Broadly, the techno-commercial feasibility of buying oil from a certain seller is a comprehensive evaluation to ascertain if the crude oil under consider-

ation is technically compatible with the refineries, and is commercially and logistically practical to purchase.

Key considerations for Indian refiners to tap into Iranian barrels would primarily include their view of the scope and durability of sanctions relief, pricing structure, and the availability of payment, insurance, and logistics mechanisms, according to industry analysts. Apart from Iran's petroleum sector, its financial sector is also under US sanctions, creating payment-related and other logistical constraints in its oil trade. Refinery executives said calls on Iranian oil imports will be taken once there is clarity on all these aspects.

While the US waiver pertains specifically to Iran's oil, petroleum product, and petrochemical exports, and not to the financial sector sanctions on Tehran, the waiver notification does mention that payments for such purchases will be allowed in dollar-denominated funds. This could help ease some, if not all, payment-related pain points pertaining to purchase of Iranian energy.

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RBI's 'STATE OF THE ECONOMY' ARTICLE

'Monsoon shortfall could weigh on growth, inflation'

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 22

THE RESERVE Bank of India's (RBI) 'State of the Economy' article has cautioned that an adverse south-west monsoon, if it materialises, could weigh on the domestic growth and inflation outlook.

As per the updated forecast of the India Meteorological Department (IMD) (released on May 29, 2026), the south-west monsoon (SWM) rainfall is likely to be below normal this year, it said. "The SWM arrived over Kerala on June 4, three days later than the normal date of onset (June 1). While the SWM has covered southern and parts of eastern regions so far, the cumulative rainfall (June 1-21) at the country level has been significantly lower than the normal," the article authored by RBI researchers and published in the RBI monthly bulletin said.

The reservoir position has slipped below last year. However, it remains above the decadal average, it said. "Given the good harvest last year, the public procurement of wheat has been robust. The public stock of rice and wheat with the Food Corporation of India is well above the buffer norms which may serve as a strategic cushion against any supply disruption or spike in prices triggered by a likely *El Niño* weather phenomenon," the article said.

"Views expressed in this article are those of the authors and do not represent the views of the Reserve Bank of India," the central bank said.

The RBI's Monetary Policy Committee had re-assessed both its growth and inflation projections, with risks emanating from elevated oil prices, uncertainty in global trade, adverse weather conditions and geopolitical ten-

RBI sold \$8.94 bn in Apr to defend rupee amid outflows, oil spike

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) made net sales of \$8.94 billion in the spot foreign exchange market in April to stabilise the rupee which was under pressure due to capital outflows and the rise in crude oil prices.

In March, it had sold \$9.75 billion to support the currency amid the West Asia conflict and its impact, according to the RBI data published in its monthly bulletin.

The central bank made purchases of \$16.22 billion and sales of \$25.16 billion in April. The outstanding net for-

ward sales stood at \$95.30 billion as of April, it said.

The rupee recovered in June after the RBI announced a series of measures like swap facility on FCNR(B) deposits and sops in bond purchases by foreign investors.

"The Indian rupee remained under pressure in May amid protracted geopolitical tensions and continued foreign portfolio outflows. However, the rupee recovered in June 2026, owing to capital flow measures, easing geopolitical tensions and falling crude oil prices," the RBI said. **ENS**

sions clouding the economic outlook. In its meeting held on June 5, it lowered the growth projection from 6.9% to 6.6% and hiked the inflation forecast from 4.6% to 5.1%.

Any breakdown of the interim US-Iran peace agreement may reignite material risks in terms of inflationary expectations, disrupted critical energy infrastructure, delayed investment spending, food security concerns, adverse financial stability outlook and structurally lower growth, the article said.

However, it said high frequency indicators during the first two months suggest sustained economic momentum in 2026-27 even as "domestic demand remained strong in May, supported by pick-up in urban demand". The uncertainties could have an impact on the outlook through international trade, cost pressures, capital flows and commodity prices, it said. According to the article, the global economic

landscape remains fragile despite some respite through the interim US-Iran peace agreement. "The Indian economy entered this turbulence with much better fundamentals relative to many other countries to sustain the shock," it stated.

It said India maintained a consistently high growth, anchored inflation expectations, sustained fiscal consolidation, manageable current account balance and foreign exchange buffers over the previous few years, which adds to its strength *vis-à-vis* other similar events in the past.

Amid the challenging global environment, the Indian economy grew at 7.8% in Q4 2025-26, led by private consumption and fixed investment.

As per the report, high-frequency indicators point towards resilience of economic activity in May. E-way bills continued to achieve double-digit growth. **FULL REPORT ON**
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Grid India proposes to repurpose underutilised thermal power plants

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, June 22

THE GRID Controller of India (Grid India) identified nine thermal power units with a combined capacity of about 1.8 gigawatts (GW) that can be repurposed as synchronous condensers (SYNCONs), a move aimed at strengthening grid reliability as India navigates the challenges of integrating rapidly growing renewable energy capacity.

Of the shortlisted power plants, eight are coal- or lignite-based, while one is gas-based. All of them are either under prolonged outage or operating at very low utilisation levels, making them potential candidates for conversion rather than continued power generation.

The proposal follows a review meeting on summer power preparedness held in April under the chairmanship of the Union Power Secretary Pan-kaj Agarwal, where stakeholders were asked to explore the possibility of converting underutilised thermal assets into grid-support infrastructure.

"The units of thermal power plants (including gas-based power plants) which are not in operation or otherwise operating sub-optimally may be considered for conversion into SYNCON (synchronous condenser). A suitable compensation mechanism may also be explored," the minutes of the meeting noted.

Asynchronous condenser is a generator that spins freely without producing electricity. Instead, it provides inertia, reactive power and voltage support to the grid, helping maintain stability during sudden fluctuations in power demand or supply.

Grid operators often de-



India faces the challenge of integrating rapidly growing RE capacity. EXPRESS PHOTO

scribe it as an electrical shock absorber that keeps the system balanced, particularly as increasing shares of solar and wind power reduce the stabilising influence provided by large thermal generators.

The proposed list spans five states and includes a mix of coal, lignite and gas-based assets that are either idle or significantly underutilised.

Of the nine shortlisted plants, Rajasthan accounts for the largest share with three facilities — Giral Thermal Power Station, Kota Super Thermal Power Station and Dholpur Gas Power Station. Gujarat has two plants on the list: Akrimota Lignite-Based Thermal Power Station and Kutch Lignite Thermal Power Station.

The list also includes Maharashtra's GEPL Phase-I Thermal Power Station and Miham Thermal Power Station, along with Raichur Thermal Power Station in Karnataka and Tuticorin Thermal Power Station in Tamil Nadu.

Grid India noted that thermal units have inherent capabil-

ity to provide reliability support such as inertial response (for frequency stability), short-circuit current (for grid strength, transient stability), voltage control and primary response (for frequency stability) to the grid.

It also cited examples from the US, UK and Mexico where thermal power units have been converted into synchronous condensers, demonstrating the viability of such repurposing. "Such repurposing can be a pragmatic option to retain the essential reliability services inherently available from synchronous machines, especially at load centres and near large renewable energy complexes," it added. In its note, Grid India said the need for synchronous condensers has been underscored by recent grid disturbances, technical studies and expert committee recommendations in India and abroad.

It cited the June 2024 grid event triggered by the tripping of the Champa-Kurukshetra HVDC link, which led to a load reduction of about 16.5 GW across the Northern Region and exposed voltage stability challenges, highlighting the role of thermal units in providing voltage and reactive power support during contingencies.

It also referred to recommendations of the Northern Regional Power Committee, which assessed system strength in the Rajasthan Renewable Energy Complex and called for the deployment of synchronous condensers at multiple locations.

According to Grid India, the need for synchronous condensers is becoming increasingly pronounced as renewable energy assumes a larger share of the power mix.

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WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Core sector growth falls to 7-mth low of 0.5% in May

New Delhi: India's core sector growth fell to 0.5% in May, the lowest in seven months as output from five of the eight constituents of the relevant index contracted year-on-year. Output of coal, crude oil, natural gas, refinery products and fertilisers fell while steel, cement and electricity production expanded.

For April, the growth had been revised to 1.8% from the 1.7% reported earlier. In May of 2025 ICI had expanded at 1.2%.

The refinery sector, which contracted by 8.7%, was the biggest drag on growth in May. It

has the highest weight of 28.04 in the ICI. Coal output fell 9.3%, crude oil 4.6%, natural gas 4.9% and fertilizers 0.9%.

"The decline in production of crude oil, refinery products and natural gas could be due to higher crude imports and softening international market prices. In the case of natural gas, with supply chains being addressed, domestic production tended to fall. Lower exports of petro products also contributed to decline in production," Chief Economist at Bank of Baroda Madan Sabnavis said. **FE**

BRIEFLY

US FTA: India seeks preferential access, says Goyal

New Delhi: Trade minister Piyush Goyal said on Monday that the trade deal with the US is taking a

little longer to sign due to the 50% tariff that was imposed on goods from the country. India aims to gain preferential access through the trade pact with the US, Goyal said while speaking at a media conclave in New Delhi. **REUTERS**